COLOSSIANS · STUDY 09 OF 12

Colossians 3:12–17

Service Manual for the Lord's Army

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 3:12–17 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

3:12 *So, as those who have been chosen of God, holy and beloved, put on a heart of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience;*

13 *bearing with one another, and forgiving each other, whoever has a complaint against anyone; just as the Lord forgave you, so also should you.*

14 *Beyond all these things put on love, which is the perfect bond of unity.*

15 *Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, to which indeed you were called in one body; and be thankful.*

16 *Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you, with all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another with psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts to God.*

17 *Whatever you do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks through Him to God the Father.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Dressed for Duty

> *“Beyond all these things put on love, which is the perfect bond of unity”*
> *— Colossians 3:14 (NASB95)*

Every army has a uniform and a code of conduct. In the last passage Paul told us to take off the old clothes of anger, malice, and lies. Now he hands us the new uniform: compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience. We wear it by bearing with one another and forgiving one another, just as the Lord forgave us.

Why should we dress this way? Because of whose we are, what we are, and why we are. We are chosen of God, set apart as holy, and dearly loved. A soldier does not put on the uniform to become a soldier; he puts it on because he already is one. And over it all Paul says to put on love, the belt that holds every other piece in place.

Then comes the code of conduct. Let the peace of Christ act as umpire in your decisions. Let the word of Christ live in you richly, until it overflows in song. And whatever you do, in word or deed, do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus, with thanks to the Father. That is not a long list of rules. It is a life shaped by Christ.

For reflection

1. Which piece of the new uniform in verse 12 do you most often leave in the closet?
2. Is there someone you are still holding a complaint against? What would it mean to forgive "just as the Lord forgave you"?
3. How richly does the word of Christ dwell in you right now? What would make it richer?

Chosen, holy, beloved: dress like who you are, and let love hold it all together.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Because believers are chosen of God, holy, and beloved, they must put on Christlike character, bearing with and forgiving one another as the Lord forgave them and binding it all with love, and they must order their lives by the peace of Christ, the word of Christ, and the name of Christ, with thankfulness.

Outline

I. The Dress Code (3:12–14)
- A. Why We Wear It (3:12a)
- B. What We Are to Wear (3:12b)
- C. How We Are to Wear It (3:13)
- D. How to Keep It On (3:14)

II. The Code of Conduct (3:15–17)
- A. The Peace of Christ Is for Arbitration (3:15)
- B. The Word of Christ Is for Application (3:16)
- C. The Name of Christ Is for Authorization (3:17)

Introduction

"So" (v.12; *oun*, "therefore") connects this passage to what came before. Because believers have put on the new self (3:10), have become members of one body (3:15), and live where there are no distinctions among members (3:11), they should live with appropriate attributes and attitudes.

In verse 8 Paul listed five vices to put off: anger, wrath, malice, slander, and abusive speech. If you think of yourself as what you were, you will keep doing those things. But if you think of yourself as what you are (v.12a), you will do the things in this passage. We may call it a service manual for the Lord's army, with a dress code (vv.12–14) and a code of conduct (vv.15–17).

I. The Dress Code (3:12–14)

A. Why We Wear It (3:12a)

Paul begins with the believer's identity, and it is the reason for everything that follows. Three descriptions tell us whose we are, what we are, and why we are.

1. Whose we are: chosen of God

"As those who have been chosen of God." Whenever the Bible speaks of God's choosing, it does so to encourage believers, not to make them anxious. Scripture speaks of believers chosen in Christ "before the foundation of the world" for blessing and for holiness (Eph. 1:4; 1 Pet. 1:1–2), and predestined "to become conformed to the image of His Son" (Rom. 8:29).

God's purpose for His people includes both their salvation and their sanctification. We were not born sinless; something had to happen between our birth in sin and our growth in holiness, and that something was our salvation by grace through faith.

2. What we are: holy

"Holy" (*hagioi*), the same word as "saints" (1:2). Saints are separated to God from the world, holy ones in position. The Corinthian church was a sinful church; Paul's first letter was written largely to correct its sins. Yet he called them "saints by calling" (1 Cor. 1:2). And they were, positionally. To the Corinthians, to the Colossians, and to us, the message is the same: bring your practice up to your position.

3. Why we are: beloved

"And beloved" (*ēgapēmenoi*, perfect passive: loved and remaining loved). God loves us. That is why He bothers with us at all. And His love for us argues for a similar love on our part toward one another.

B. What We Are to Wear (3:12b)

"Put on" (*endysasthe*) is the clothing word again, the opposite of "put aside" in verse 8. The five virtues fall into three groups: how we treat others, how we estimate ourselves, and how we respond when others mistreat us.

1. Our treatment of others

- **A heart of compassion** (*splanchna oiktirmou*, literally "bowels of mercy"): sensitivity to those who are suffering and in need. Compassion is your hurt in my heart.
- **Kindness** (*chrēstotēs*): a sweet disposition that shows itself in thoughtful dealings with others.

2. Our estimate of ourselves

- **Humility** (*tapeinophrosynē*): a realistic view of oneself, "thinking lowly of ourselves because we are lowly." Note the contrast with the false humility of 2:18, 23.
- **Gentleness** (*prautēs*): not behaving harshly, arrogantly, or self-assertively, but with consideration for others. It is not weakness; it is strength under control.

3. Our response to provocation

- **Patience** (*makrothymia*): long-suffering, self-restraint that does not retaliate (see 1:11). The two participles of verse 13 expand on it.

C. How We Are to Wear It (3:13)

1. Bearing with one another

"Bearing with one another" (*anechomenoi*). Forbearing means putting up with others and enduring discomfort. Bear with one another, not only when it is comfortable, but especially when it is not.

2. Forgiving each other

"And forgiving each other, whoever has a complaint against anyone." The verb (*charizomenoi*) is built on *charis*, grace: to forgive is to give grace. Forgiving means not holding a grudge or nursing a grievance. How? "Just as the Lord forgave you, so also should you" (compare Eph. 4:32). The Lord forgave us graciously, freely, and fully, all our transgressions (2:13). Grudges have no place in a believer's life, because they lead straight back to the sins of 3:8–9.

D. How to Keep It On (3:14)

"Beyond all these things put on love, which is the perfect bond of unity." The preposition (*epi*) can mean "upon" or "over." Paul is not merely saying love is more important; he is picturing love as the outer garment or belt that goes on top of everything else and holds it all in place. Love is the "bond" (*syndesmos*), the ligament that binds the virtues together into a complete, mature character. Look at every other virtue in the list: without love, each one fails. Compassion without love becomes pity; humility without love becomes self-absorption; patience without love becomes cold endurance.

II. The Code of Conduct (3:15–17)

A. The Peace of Christ Is for Arbitration (3:15)

"Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, to which indeed you were called in one body; and be thankful." The word "rule" (*brabeuō*) means to act as umpire, to make the call. (It is related to the word for "prize" in 2:18.) When choosing between two or more options, let peace make the call.

Some take this to mean that whatever gives me an inner feeling of peace must be God's choice. But the context points beyond private feelings. Paul seems to be saying that we should choose the course that preserves peace with God, "rule in your hearts," and peace with one another, "to which indeed you were called in one body," as long as the choice lies within God's revealed moral will (compare John 14:27). And then: "be thankful." When there is peace with God, peace among ourselves, and thankful hearts, we will not make many wrong decisions.

B. The Word of Christ Is for Application (3:16)

"Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you." The phrase "the word of Christ" occurs only here in the New Testament. It means Christ's teaching, not only from His earthly ministry but in all of Scripture, which is His Word. It should "dwell" (*enoikeitō*, make its home) in us "richly," permeating our whole being so that we make every decision and plan in its light. Many believers cannot honestly say that God's Word dwells in them richly, simply because they do not take time to read, study, meditate on, and memorize it.

"With all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another." Teaching is the imparting of truth; admonishing is warning against error (1:28). Both are the work of every believer, not only of pastors, and both are to be done with grace. And notice one of the means: "with psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts to God."

- **Psalms** probably refers to the inspired Old Testament psalms, sung with or without instruments.
- **Hymns** are songs of praise and thanksgiving to God.
- **Spiritual songs** probably refers to expressions of Christian experience set to music.

Compare the remarkably similar passage in Ephesians 5:18–21. There the command is to "be filled with the Spirit," and the results are speaking to one another in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing, giving thanks, and mutual submission. Here the command is to let the word of Christ dwell richly, and the results are teaching and admonishing in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing, giving thanks (v.17), and then submission in the home (v.18). The parallel is striking: the Spirit-filled life and the Word-filled life produce the same results. They are two sides of the same reality. The Spirit fills us as the Word of Christ dwells in us.

C. The Name of Christ Is for Authorization (3:17)

"Whatever you do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks through Him to God the Father." The New Covenant does not hand believers a detailed list of rules for every situation. The Old Covenant had its commandments, and the rabbis added hundreds more. Paul explains the difference in Galatians 4:1–7: codes of rules suited the period of childhood under guardians. A son who has come of age knows his father's will without needing a long list of do's and don'ts.

What the New Testament does provide is basic principles of Christian living that can be applied to every situation as it arises. This verse is one of the broadest. To do something "in the name of the Lord Jesus" is to do it as His representative, consistent with His character, for His glory, and with His authorization. If you cannot do it in His name and give thanks for it, do not do it. And for the third time in three verses, Paul calls for thanksgiving (vv.15, 16, 17).

Conclusion

The Lord's army has a uniform and a code of conduct. The uniform is Christlike character: compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, patience, forbearance, and forgiveness, all held in place by love. The code is not a thick rulebook but three principles: let the peace of Christ make the call, let the word of Christ live in you richly, and let the name of Christ authorize everything you say and do.

We do not dress this way to become chosen, holy, and beloved. We dress this way because we already are.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.12	**ἐκλεκτός** *chosen*	**G1588** *eklektos* Nom. Masc. Pl.	**VINE:** picked out, chosen; used of believers as objects of God's choice. **Significance:** A word of encouragement: believers belong to God by His choice.
v.12	**ἀγαπάω** *beloved*	**G25** *agapaō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**ATR:** perfect passive: loved and remaining loved. **Significance:** God's settled love is the motive for our love.
v.12	**ἐνδύω** *put on*	**G1746** *endyō* Aor. Mid. Imp. 2nd Pl.	**THAY:** to put on, clothe oneself. **Significance:** The opposite of "put aside" (3:8): dress in the new wardrobe.
v.12	**σπλάγχνον** *heart (of compassion)*	**G4698** *splanchnon* Acc. Neut. Pl.	**VINE:** the inward parts, seat of tender affection; with *oiktirmos*, "bowels of mercy." **Significance:** Compassion felt deeply: your hurt in my heart.
v.12	**χρηστότης** *kindness*	**G5544** *chrēstotēs* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** moral goodness, kindness, gentle benevolence. **Significance:** A sweet disposition expressed in thoughtful dealings.
v.12	**πραΰτης** *gentleness*	**G4240** *prautēs* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** not weakness but strength under control; consideration for others. **Significance:** Refuses harshness and self-assertion.
v.13	**ἀνέχω** *bearing with*	**G430** *anechō* Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** to hold oneself up against, put up with, endure. **Significance:** Putting up with others, especially when uncomfortable.
v.13	**χαρίζομαι** *forgiving*	**G5483** *charizomai* Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to grant as a favor, to pardon; built on *charis*. **Significance:** To forgive is to give grace, as the Lord did.
v.14	**σύνδεσμος** *bond*	**G4886** *syndesmos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**MRV:** that which binds together, a ligament (cf. 2:19). **Significance:** Love holds all the other virtues in place.
v.15	**βραβεύω** *rule*	**G1018** *brabeuō* Pres. Act. Imp. 3rd Sg.	**THAY:** to be an umpire, decide, direct. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** Let Christ's peace make the call in

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
			choices within God's will.
v.16	**ἐνοικέω** *dwell*	**G1774** *enoikeō* Pres. Act. Imp. 3rd Sg.	**VINE:** to dwell in, inhabit, be at home in. **Significance:** The word of Christ is to be at home in us, richly.
v.16	**ψαλμός** *psalms*	**G5568** *psalmos* Dat. Masc. Pl.	**LXX:** the title of the Book of Psalms; a song sung to an instrument. **Significance:** Likely the inspired OT psalms.
v.16	**ὕμνος** *hymns*	**G5215** *hymnos* Dat. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** a song of praise. **Significance:** Songs addressed to God in praise.
v.16	**ᾠδή** *songs*	**G5603** *ōdē* Dat. Fem. Pl.	**VINE:** a general word for song; "spiritual" specifies its character. **Significance:** Christian experience set to music.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
What three descriptions in v.12a give the motive for the dress code?	Chosen of God (whose we are), holy (what we are), beloved (why we are).
Group the five virtues of v.12b.	Treatment of others (compassion, kindness); estimate of self (humility, gentleness); response to provocation (patience).
What is the standard for forgiveness (v.13)?	"Just as the Lord forgave you": graciously, freely, fully.
What picture does "put on love" convey (v.14)?	The outer garment or belt that holds all the other virtues in place.
Name the three principles of the code of conduct (vv.15–17).	The peace of Christ (arbitration), the word of Christ (application), the name of Christ (authorization).

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Why does Paul remind believers that they are "chosen of God, holy and beloved" before giving commands?

> **Leader's answer:** Our conduct flows from our identity. We do not put on these virtues to become

God's people; we put them on because we already are His chosen, holy, and beloved people.

2. How does the standard "just as the Lord forgave you" change the way we forgive?

Leader's answer: The Lord forgave us freely, fully, and while we were undeserving. That leaves no room for grudges or conditions; we extend the same grace we received.

3. How should the "peace of Christ" function in decision-making, according to the study?

Leader's answer: As an umpire that makes the call: choose the course that preserves peace with God and peace in the body, within God's revealed moral will, not simply whatever produces a private feeling of calm.

4. Compare Colossians 3:16–18 with Ephesians 5:18–21. What does the comparison teach?

Leader's answer: The Word-filled life and the Spirit-filled life produce the same results: speaking in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing, thanksgiving, and submission. The Spirit fills us as the word of Christ dwells in us richly.

5. Why does the New Covenant give principles like 3:17 rather than detailed rule lists?

Leader's answer: Detailed codes suited the period of spiritual childhood under the Law (Gal. 4:1–7). Mature sons know the Father's will and apply broad principles, such as doing everything in Jesus' name with thanks, to every situation.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
3:12a	Our identity	Chosen of God, holy, and beloved.
3:12b–13	Our wardrobe	Compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, patience; bearing with and forgiving one another.
3:14	Our belt	Love, the perfect bond of unity.
3:15–17	Our code	Peace of Christ as umpire, word of Christ dwelling richly, all in the name of the Lord Jesus with thanks.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Get Dressed on Purpose

Scripture anchor: Colossians 3:12

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.B, and ② Devotional

We choose our clothes every morning. Paul calls us to choose our character the same way. Before the day begins, deliberately "put on" compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience, especially toward the people most likely to test them.

Reflection: Which person in your life most needs to see you wearing the new wardrobe this week?

Practical step: Each morning this week, pray through the five virtues of verse 12 by name as you get dressed.

2. Forgive as You Were Forgiven

Scripture anchor: Colossians 3:13; Ephesians 4:32

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.C.2, and ④ Study Question 2

Forgiveness is grace given away. We do not forgive because the other person deserves it, but because the Lord forgave us when we did not. Holding a grudge keeps the old clothes of anger and malice close at hand.

Reflection: Is there a complaint you are still holding against someone?

Practical step: Choose to forgive that person before God in prayer this week, and if appropriate, take one step toward reconciliation.

3. Let the Word Move In

Scripture anchor: Colossians 3:16

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.B; cf. Jensen, How to Profit from Bible Reading (FGR)

The word of Christ is meant to be at home in us, richly. Irving Jensen spent his career helping ordinary believers read the Bible for themselves, slowly and observantly. A Word-filled believer teaches, encourages, and sings, and the Spirit uses that Word to fill him.

Reflection: How much of the Bible is "at home" in your memory and thoughts?

Practical step: Memorize Colossians 3:16–17 this week and sing or listen to one hymn based on Scripture each day.

4. Do It in His Name

Scripture anchor: Colossians 3:17

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.C

Verse 17 is a simple test for gray areas: can I do this in the name of the Lord Jesus, as His representative, and give thanks to the Father for it? That principle reaches into work, entertainment, speech, and spending.

Reflection: Is there something in your regular routine you could not honestly do "in the name of the Lord Jesus"?

Practical step: Apply the verse 17 test to one decision each day this week, and write down what you learn.

End of Study · Colossians 3:12–17